

The Montessori Classroom Setup Guide

*An AMI-aligned guide to the prepared environment
for children ages 3 to 6*

Montessori Life Skills
montessorilifeskillsapp.com

Six Principles of the Prepared Environment

Everything in a Montessori classroom exists for a reason. These six principles govern every choice you make when preparing the space.

Order

The environment must be ordered, because the child between three and six is in the sensitive period for order. Every material has a fixed place on the shelf, and the child always returns it there.

Beauty

The room must be beautiful – light, airy, with fresh flowers, plants, and carefully chosen pictures hung at the child's eye level.

Reality

Tools must be real and they must work. The child drinks from a real glass, pours from a real ceramic jug, sweeps with a real broom.

Freedom within limits

The child is free to choose work and repeat it, provided the work is not misused and does not disturb others.

Child-sized proportions

Every piece of furniture and every tool is proportioned to the child and light enough for the child to move.

One of each material

There is only one of each material in the room. This teaches waiting, turn-taking, and respect for another's work.

The Curriculum Areas

Practical Life

The first area. Everything begins here.

- Preliminary exercises – spooning, pouring, carrying a tray, opening and closing
- Care of the person – dressing frames, hand washing, food preparation
- Care of the environment – dusting, sweeping, washing a table, flower arranging
- Grace and courtesy – greeting, offering, waiting, observing another's work
- Control of movement – walking on the line, the silence game

Practical Life is offered exclusively at the start. No other curriculum area is introduced until the child's Practical Life work is settled.

Sensorial

Introduced once Practical Life work is settled.

- Visual – pink tower, brown stair, red rods, knobbed cylinders
- Tactile – touch boards, touch tablets, fabric box
- Chromatic – colour tablets, boxes one through three
- Auditory – sound cylinders, the bells
- Baric, thermic, stereognostic, olfactory and gustatory

Each material isolates a single sensory quality and carries its own control of error.

Language

Runs alongside Sensorial, once speech is confident.

- Enrichment of vocabulary – classified cards, three-period lessons
- Sound games (I Spy) – beginning, ending, then middle sounds
- Sandpaper letters – tracing sound and shape together
- Moveable alphabet – composing words before writing by hand
- Writing, then reading – phonetic words first

Writing precedes reading in the AMI sequence.

Mathematics

Introduced when the child shows readiness.

- Numbers one to ten – number rods, sandpaper numbers, spindle box, cards and counters
- The decimal system – golden beads: unit, ten, hundred, thousand
- Teens and tens – Seguin boards, coloured bead stair
- Linear counting – the hundred chain and thousand chain
- Memorization – the operation tables

Every quantity is first presented concretely; the symbol always follows.

Culture

Woven through the environment from the start.

- Geography – land and water forms, globes, puzzle maps
- Botany – leaf cabinet, parts of a plant, care of plants
- Zoology – classification, care of classroom animals
- Art and music – real art at child height, singing, the bells

Geography begins with the whole and moves to the parts.

How the Shelves Are Arranged

- Materials are arranged left to right, top to bottom, simplest to most complex.
- Every activity is complete and self-contained on its own tray, basket, or stand.
- Each material isolates one difficulty.
- Wherever possible the material carries a control of error.
- Broken, incomplete, or worn materials are repaired or removed the same day.
- Low, open shelving lets the child see the whole room's work at a glance and choose freely.

The Role of the Adult

- Prepare the environment, then step back. The adult is the link between the child and the environment, not the centre of it.
- Observe before intervening.
- Present each activity individually, slowly, with precise and economical movements.
- Present, then withdraw. The child learns through repetition.
- Guard concentration above all. Never interrupt a child who is working, not even to praise.
- Re-present an activity as often as needed, without comment.

The Essentials Checklist

- Low open shelves, no higher than the child's shoulder
- Child-sized tables and chairs, light enough to be moved by the child
- Work rugs rolled and standing in a basket
- An ellipse marked on the floor for Walking on the Line
- Real, breakable glasses, jugs and plates in the Practical Life area
- Child-sized broom, dustpan, mop, dusting and polishing cloths, all accessible
- A food preparation area with real child-sized tools
- Plants to care for, fresh flowers to arrange, natural light
- One complete set of each material, arranged on trays, simplest to most complex
- Art prints hung at the child's eye level, rotated regularly
- A quiet corner of the shelf for the Silence Game
- Nothing decorative that does not serve the child's work

When you are ready for the full AMI sequence – eight curriculum areas and hundreds of activities with step-by-step presentations – it is waiting inside the Montessori Life Skills app.